India's strategy was far less clear than that of China, although it had the stronger hand to play. Recognition of a new regime by the world at large is the highest form of international legitimacy. It, thus, gives considerable leverage to the recognizing state to secure its own interests vis-à-vis the new regime. The leverage that the state may have is also proportionate to its own international standing; the greater its global reputation and stature, the more desirable it becomes to the party that is seeking to secure its support. In this regard, India was in a position of great advantage. Not only was it looked upon by the West as a shining example of democracy in the Third World and as a leading country in Asia in the aftermath of the Second World War, Prime Minister Nehru also had international stature and commanded the respect of his peers. India, thus, held adequate international political capital to secure its interests vis-à-vis the new regime in China. The matter would now hinge on India's strategies and tactics in the diplomatic negotiations.

Nehru's instructions to Panikkar in September 1949, before he returned to India, was that the latter should raise with the Chinese side the issue of the frontier between India and Tibet, as well as matters concerning India's special privileges in Tibet (which it had inherited from Great Britain in 1947). Nehru's message indicated that the Government of India was thinking of making the boundary question and the status of Tibet a part of the negotiations with China on diplomatic recognition. This made good sense. If the Chinese Communists intended to make good on their declaration to reclaim Tibet, it would have security implications for India's northern frontier. Secretary General of the Ministry of External Affairs Girija Shankar Bajpai put it thus: 'We cannot, however, without the most careful consideration give up the special relationship that we have had with Tibet. My provisional view is that this is one of the matters